as the Brigadier Administration in XV Corps overseeing the developments in Ladakh. The offer was accepted at once, even though it meant going from one ‘field’ posting to another. Though Lieutenant General Bikram Singh, the XV Corps Commander, protested vigorously, Dalvi found himself on the train to Rangiya towards the end of February.

1/9 Gorkha Rifles (GR), commanded by Lieutenant Colonel B. S. Ahluwalia, was stationed at Tawang while 1 Sikh, commanded by Lieutenant Colonel B. M. ‘Baij’ Mehta, was at Dirang Dzong. The third battalion that made up 7 Infantry Brigade was 9 Punjab under the command of Lieutenant Colonel Byram Master. The Punjabis had been airlifted into Tezpur in December even though there was no apparent reason for this move to have taken place.

Dalvi was taken aback at the complete lack of any real infrastructure despite the fact that 4 Infantry Division had been in the area for two years. The condition of the troops at the ‘rear’ in Rangiya and Missamari did not inspire too much confidence about the facilities further in the hills. The route from the foothills over which the Line of Communication extended for 7 Infantry Brigade was incredible. There was a steep, almost vertical climb through dense rain forest to Eaglenest at 9,000 feet, then a drop to Chacko and Rupa before another climb from Tenga to Bomdila (10,000 feet); another drop to Thembang and Dirang Dzong (5,500 feet) before negotiating yet another climb to Senge and the windswept Se-la (13,700 feet); once again, after dropping down to Nuranang, the road almost plummeted vertically to Jang (5,000 feet) before crossing the Mago Chu and climbing back to Tawang (10,000 feet).

Just beyond Dirang Dzong was Sapper Camp where Dalvi met the commanding officer of the Tuskers, Lieutenant Colonel Sandhu. The Border Roads Organisation had been hard at work having started surveying the road in 1960 after 4 Infantry Division moved in from the Punjab. Any road cut in the southern slopes of the Himalayas, especially in this region, would take years to settle down. Despite the fact that it had taken Sandhu and his men a few months to reconnoitre and select the final alignment while simultaneously dumping stores and equipment required for the job, in a remarkable feat of engineering, they had completed a fair weather road by the end of 1961. In November, both the chief, Thapar, and the CGS, Kaul, had visited the region and proceeded along the newly laid road up to Tawang. The condition of the road, however, was another matter. Jeeps